

Using the GNOME Desktop

The desktop view

When you first start up your desktop, depending upon your distribution, you may see a fairly spartan view. With any GNOME desktop there is an empty desktop and a single bar across the top. The bar simply shows the word 'Activities' at the left. A Clock in the middle and a few icons at the right hand side. If you are using Ubuntu or some other more user friendly Linux distributions, you may have some other icons on a 'dock', either on the left hand side, or at the bottom (see the screenshot at the beginning of this page for an example of the Ubuntu desktop GNOME experience).

Your Applications

The apps on the dock that come 'favourited' as standard in Ubuntu are the Firefox web browser, Thunderbird email, Files (the file explorer), Rhythmbox (music player), LibreOffice Writer (word processor), The Ubuntu Software Centre (to install more apps with). The final two icons are GNOME help and a link to Amazon. Note that the apps that come with your Linux distribution may vary from the ones listed here.

At the very bottom of your screen you'll see an icon that looks like a 3×3 grid of boxes, this is 'Show Applications', much like the Windows 'pane' icon on your start menu brings up your Apps. If you download/install new apps, they appear when you click on this icon. You can add any of the apps from your applications list to your favourites on the Dock by right clicking their icon and selecting 'Add to Favourites'.

If you left click on any of the icons, as you'd expect, the app is launched. If you right click with your mouse, you will see a context menu. For example, right click on the Firefox icon and you'll see a few options such as 'New Window'. The options available are obviously different depending on the app, thus the name 'context menu'.

Activities

Clicking on the text at the top of the screen 'Activities' brings up a screen with a zoomed-out look of all the applications you are presently running. It also gives you the ability to search for other applications you can run. If you start typing an app's name into the search bar, it will appear in the results. Simply hit return and the app will launch, which is a quick way to launch apps.

The image on the right shows the Activities view. The dock shows the favourites on the left hand side. Notice that beneath the Firefox and Files icons there is a blue 'underline' (this will be a small dot in Ubuntu). This shows that those apps are running. You'll notice that any normal apps also appear zoomed out when you are in the Activities view. This is kind of like Mission Control if you are used to a Mac. You'll notice that both of the running apps, Firefox and Files are zoomed out here, placed side by side with the text below them describing what the App is. If you click on any of these 'thumb-nailed' (zoomed out) images of the apps and it will immediately zoom back in to that particular app, making it very quick to switch between Apps.

Tux tip: Press your Windows key on your keyboard (cmd on a mac) and you will automatically be taken to the Activities view so it's even faster to get there!

Getting Virtual with desktops

A theme that has now become common across Windows, Mac and GNOME is the notion of Virtual Desktops. The benefit of having virtual desktops is that you can de-clutter your desktop workspace. Having lots of windows open on one desktop can quickly get distracting.

To launch a virtual desktop, enter the Activities view. On the right hand side you'll see a drawer containing two thumbnails of a desktop; hover your mouse over the drawer, and the drawer automatically slides out. The desktop thumbnail at the top is the current (first) desktop. The next one is a blank desktop. Click on it and you'll have a fresh desktop. If you launch an app now, it will start up on this second desktop. If you want to go back to the apps you were running on the first desktop, simply enter the Activities view once again, and click on the first desktop in the drawer. Notice also that once you have apps running in the second desktop, a third virtual desktop is created for you automatically.

Where are my files?

You'll see 'Files' listed in the dock as one of the favourites. Click on this and you'll see a file browser much like any other you may be used to. By default, you'll be in grid (icons) view. On the right, note there are different views that can help you organise your files. The button with the 6 dots/dashes on it (top right) indicates that you are in grid view. The button to the immediate left with three dashed lines indicates the detailed view, which is what you can see in this screenshot. If you want extra details to appear by default in the list view. Click on the button with the down arrow and click 'Visible columns'.

On the left hand pane of the file navigator, you'll see favourite locations. You can add a location to your bookmarks (below the favourites) simply by dragging and dropping the folder of your choice to there.

If you have set up an online account set up with the likes of Google Drive/Microsoft OneDrive/Nextcloud etc, you'll see any connected drives you might have. In this case, I have my Google Drive available. Clicking on this will allow you to view the files in your drive just as it were any normal folder (albeit a bit slower!).